

3 Stick to ratings
Always use a CPU heatsink and fan combination that has been certified by AMD. If you prefer to buy a separate one, make sure it is rated and can run with your particular processor as Athlon has stringent cooling requirements.

4 Power considerations
If you plan to use the faster Athlon processors (2000+ and above) along with power-hungry peripherals such as a CD-Writer, large hard disks and a powerful graphics card, use a high-quality power supply with a rating of at least 300 watts. Most low-end power supplies cannot deliver clean power to systems built on these components, resulting in an unstable system.

12 5 Follow the instructions
AMD processors also have specialised instruction sets like 3DNow! which

streamline the power of certain applications. To realise the full potential of these processors, make sure that your applications integrate support for the special instructions. In some cases, you might need to load special patches to enable the support.

6 A matter of memory
The AMD processors let you choose between SDRAM and DDR memory. While SDRAM is the cheaper of the two, DDR memory offers higher bandwidth and it is continually evolving in terms of technology and speed. SDRAM is a good cost-effective option if you plan to run memory-intensive applications. However, DDR's inherent speed and falling prices make it a good investment for the future.

7 Which processor?
AMD gives you three choices in processors. While the Duron range offers reasonably good performance given its price, it makes sense to choose the Athlons as Duron processors are on their way out. Here again, you get to choose between the older Palomino processors built around the 0.18-micron process and the newer Thoroughbred processors built around the 0.13-micron process. While the latter boasts higher clock speeds, lower power consumption and consequently better performance, not all motherboards support them. Ensure that your motherboard

inherently supports these processors before buying them. Optionally, you could download a BIOS update that would enable the support, if your motherboard allows it.

8 Don't scrounge
A cheap motherboard will run your processor, but will also put the stability and reliability of your system at risk. Also, there are plenty of features that a good-quality motherboard allows you in the form of better hardware support, cutting-edge features and even support for overclocking. A branded motherboard will also feature BIOS and driver updates on its Web site.

9 Drive it in
Ensure that you download and run your AMD motherboard with the latest chipset drivers for high performance and to eliminate possible bugs and compatibility issues. Visit the chipset manufacturer's Web site frequently for newer driver updates.

10 BIOS updates
Make sure you buy a motherboard that offers regular BIOS and driver updates on the company Web site. This spells great support for newer hardware and helps iron out the bugs and flaws that may crop up. Newer BIOS updates can also mean significant performance boosts.

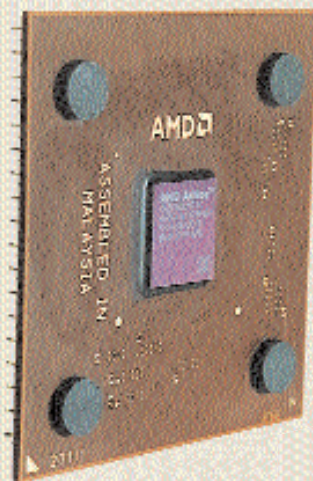
10 TIPS ON INSTALLING MOTHERBOARDS

The motherboard is the physical and electronic foundation of your system. Here are a few tips that will help smoothen the installation process and enable it to be installed in a stable manner

1 Get it set right
Before you install the motherboard, consult the accompanying manual—you may have installed motherboards numerous times, but manufacturers add last minute addendums that describe special considerations or last-minute changes incorporated into the board. Also, mark out all the jumper settings in the manual tables so that they correspond to your processor, RAM and other system

components. Tick the appropriate jumper settings; this makes it easier to implement these settings during installation.

2 Handle with caution
The motherboard has very sensitive electronic components that are susceptible to damage by static charge. Therefore, ensure that you are properly grounded (touch a metallic object to get rid of static electricity) and that the mother-



The AMD's exposed core invites damage